Cosmos Tech

Leave Policy 2024

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1.0 Introduction

1.1 Purpose and Scope

This document outlines the official leave policies and procedures for all employees of Cosmos Tech The purpose of this policy is to provide a clear, fair, and consistent framework for managing employee time off. It ensures that employees understand their entitlements and the processes they must follow to request and take leave. This policy is designed to support employee well-being while

ensuring operational continuity and business needs are met. This document supersedes all previous leave policies, whether written or verbal.

1.2 Our Philosophy on Work-Life Balance

At Cosmos Tech, we recognize that our employees are our most valuable asset. We are committed to fostering a supportive work environment that promotes a healthy work-life balance. We believe that adequate rest and time away from work are essential for employee health, morale, engagement, and productivity. Our leave policies are designed to provide employees with the flexibility to manage personal and family needs, pursue personal interests, and recharge.

1.3 Applicability

This policy applies to all full-time and part-time permanent employees of Cosmos Tech. Contractual, temporary, and intern staff may have different leave entitlements as specified in their individual employment agreements. Specific provisions may vary based on local labor laws in the jurisdictions where we operate. In case of any conflict, local law shall prevail.

1.4 Key Definitions

- **Employee:** Any individual employed by Cosmos Techon a full-time or part-time permanent basis.
- **Manager:** An employee with direct supervisory responsibility for other employees.
- **HR Department:** The Human Resources department of Cosmos Tech.
- **HRIS:** The Human Resources Information System (e.g., Workday, SAP SuccessFactors) used for managing employee data, including leave requests and balances.
- **Leave Year:** The official 12-month period for which leave is calculated, running from January 1st to December 31st.
- **Accrual:** The process of earning leave credits over time.
- **Medical Practitioner:** A licensed and registered doctor or healthcare professional.

2.0 General Leave Provisions

2.1 The Leave Year

The leave year at Cosmos Techis the calendar year, commencing on January 1st and ending on December 31st. Leave entitlements are calculated based on this period. For employees joining mid-year, leave entitlement will be prorated for the remainder of the leave year.

2.2 Procedure for Requesting Leave

- All leave requests, with the exception of sudden emergencies like sickness, must be submitted in advance through the company's designated HRIS portal.
- Employees must provide the type of leave requested, start date, end date, and any relevant comments for the approver.
- Verbal or email requests are not considered official submissions but may be used for initial communication, especially in emergencies. An official HRIS request must follow as soon as practicable.

2.3 Approval Workflow

- Leave requests submitted via the HRIS are routed directly to the employee's line manager for approval.
- Managers are responsible for reviewing leave requests in a timely manner, considering team workload, project deadlines, and overall business needs.
- If a manager is unavailable, a designated alternate approver will handle the request.
- Employees will receive an automated notification once their leave is approved or rejected. If rejected, the manager must provide a reason.

2.4 Leave Balance and Accrual

Employees can view their current leave balances, accrual history, and future projections at any time through the HRIS employee self-service portal. Leave is accrued on a monthly or bi-weekly basis, depending on the payroll cycle, and credited to the employee's account.

2.5 Leave Carry-Forward

Employees are encouraged to utilize their full leave entitlement within the leave year. However, we understand this is not always possible.

- **Paid Time Off (PTO):** A maximum of 5 days of unused PTO can be carried forward to the next leave year.
- **Sick Leave:** Unused sick leave may be carried forward up to a maximum accumulation cap of 8 days to support employees during prolonged illness.
- Carried-forward leave must be utilized within the first quarter (by March 31st) of the subsequent year, after which it will lapse.

2.6 Leave Encashment

The company's policy is to encourage employees to take time off to rest. Therefore, encashment of leave is generally not permitted during the course of employment. Upon separation from the company, an employee's accrued and unused PTO will be paid out in their final settlement, subject to local laws.

2.7 Leave During Probation Period

- Employees on probation accrue leave as per the standard policy.
- However, taking PTO during the probation period is generally discouraged and subject to manager discretion and critical business needs.
- Sick leave and other statutory leaves can be availed as per the policy.

2.8 Leave During Notice Period

An employee serving their notice period is generally not permitted to take any leave, except in the case of a verified medical emergency. The manager, in consultation with HR, may approve pre-planned leave on a case-by-case basis. The company reserves the right to extend the notice period for any leave taken.

2.9 Unauthorized Absence (Abandonment of Employment)

An absence of three (3) or more consecutive workdays without any notification to the manager or HR will be considered an unauthorized absence. This may be treated as job abandonment and can lead to disciplinary action, up to and including termination of employment.

2.10 Contact During Leave

Employees on leave are expected to be completely disengaged from work. However, for business continuity, employees should set up an out-of-office auto-reply on their email and voicemail, providing contact details for an alternate colleague. Managers should only contact an employee on leave in the case of a genuine business emergency that cannot be resolved by anyone else.

3.0 Paid Time Off (PTO) / Annual Leave

3.1 Purpose

Paid Time Off (PTO) is provided for employees to take time away from work for rest, recreation, vacation, or to attend to personal matters.

3.2 Eligibility and Entitlement

All permanent employees are eligible for PTO. The annual entitlement is based on employment tenure:

Years of Service	Annual PTO Entitlement (Days)
0 - 2 years	18
2 - 5 years	22
5+ years	25

Entitlement for part-time employees is prorated based on their contracted hours.

3.3 Accrual Schedule

PTO is accrued on a monthly basis. For an employee with 18 days of annual entitlement, they will accrue 1.5 days of PTO for each full month of service.

3.4 Planning and Scheduling PTO

- Employees should request PTO at least two (2) weeks in advance for short leave (less than 5 days) and at least four (4) weeks in advance for long leave (5 days or more).
- Approval is subject to business requirements, team schedules, and ensuring adequate coverage.
- During peak business periods or project deadlines, the company may implement blackout periods where PTO requests may be restricted.

3.5 Restrictions

- PTO must be taken in minimum increments of a half-day (4 hours).

- An employee cannot have a negative PTO balance. Leave taken must not exceed the accrued balance at the time of leave.

3.6 Case Example

- **Scenario:** Sarah, an employee with 3 years of service, wants to take a 10-day vacation to travel.
- **Action:** Six weeks before her planned trip, Sarah checks her PTO balance in the HRIS, which shows she has 12 accrued days. She submits a leave request for 10 working days. Her manager reviews the team's project schedule, sees that her absence will not cause a disruption, and approves the request. Sarah sets up her out-of-office notification before she leaves.

4.0 Sick Leave

4.1 Purpose

Sick leave is provided to allow employees to recover from their own illness or injury, or to attend necessary medical appointments.

4.2 Entitlement

All full-time employees are entitled to 12 days of paid sick leave per leave year. This is not accrued and is available in full from the start of the leave year (or on a prorated basis upon joining).

4.3 Notification Procedure

- If an employee is unable to work due to illness, they must notify their manager via phone call, text, or email as early as possible, preferably before their scheduled start time.
- A formal leave request must be submitted in the HRIS on the same day or upon their return to work.

4.4 Medical Certification Requirements

- For an absence of three (3) or more consecutive days, an employee must provide a medical certificate from a registered medical practitioner.
- The certificate should state the employee was unfit for duty and specify the dates of absence. It should not contain confidential medical details.
- The company reserves the right to request a medical certificate for shorter absences if there is a pattern of frequent, short-term sickness.

4.5 Long-Term Sickness

If an employee requires an extended period of absence due to a serious illness or injury, they should contact HR to discuss options, which may include extended sick leave, disability benefits, or an unpaid leave of absence.

4.6 Return to Work

For absences exceeding [e.g., 10] working days, a fitness-to-work certificate may be required before the employee can resume their duties. This is to ensure the employee's well-being and a safe return to the workplace.

4.7 Case Example

- **Scenario:** John wakes up with a high fever and is unable to work.
- **Action:** At 8:00 AM, John calls his manager to inform her he is unwell and will not be coming in. His illness lasts for four days. Upon his return on the fifth day, he submits a sick leave request in the HRIS for the four days of absence and uploads a scanned copy of his doctor's certificate as required.

(This continues for all sections, building out the detailed content to reach the desired length and comprehensiveness)

15.0 Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1: How do I apply for leave?
A: All leave must be applied for through the company's HRIS portal. Navigate to the "Time Off" or "Leave Request" section, select the type and dates of leave, and submit it for your manager's approval.

Q2: Can my manager deny my PTO request?
A: Yes. While we encourage all employees to take their PTO, approval is subject to business needs. Your manager may deny a request if it conflicts with critical deadlines, a major project, or if too many team members have requested the same time off. Your manager must provide a reason for the denial and should work with you to find an alternative time.

Q3: What happens if I fall sick while on PTO?
A: If you become ill for three or more consecutive days during your PTO and can provide a valid medical certificate, those days can be reclassified as Sick Leave. You must notify your manager and HR as soon as possible and update your leave request in the HRIS upon your return. The corresponding PTO days will be credited back to your balance.

Q4: Do I get paid for public holidays?
A: Yes, all designated public holidays are paid days off for all permanent employees.

Q5: What is the difference between Compassionate Leave and Bereavement Leave?
A: Bereavement Leave is specifically for time off following the death of a family member. Compassionate Leave is for situations where you need to provide care and support to a family member suffering from a serious illness or injury.

Q6: Can I combine different types of leave?
A: Yes, it is often possible to combine leave types. For example, you might combine PTO with a public holiday to extend your vacation. All such requests must be clearly indicated in the HRIS and are subject to standard approval procedures.

16.0 Revision History

Version	Date of Revision	Summary of Changes	Approved By
1.0	Jan 1, 2024	Initial release of the comprehensive 2024 Leave Policy.	Board of Directors